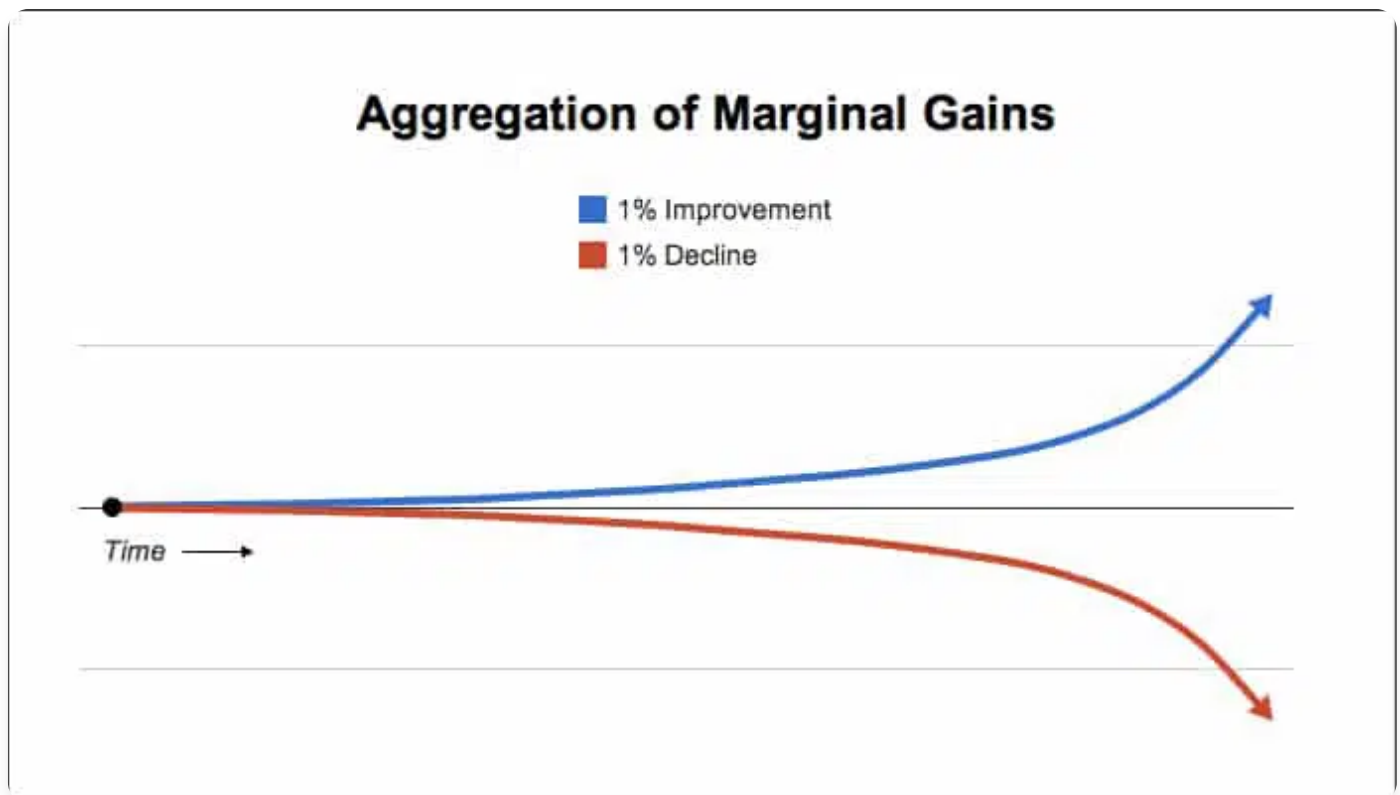


COURSE PROGRESS: 100% COMPLETE

Tracking marginal gains

Utilising marginal gains is a powerful tool to have in your toolkit. It is very rare to see in students under 25 years old, but a secret weapon of some of the most successful and high performing individuals in the world. Mastering marginal gains at a young age is a competitive advantage that very few will be able to beat, in time.



Source: Jamesclear.com

The steps

Step 1: Anchor the goal

Identify a meaningful and challenging goal that you would like to achieve. The goal should be at least 9 months away and less than 3 years away.

Step 2: Dissect the goal



Take Notes

Identify the **processes** necessary for you to achieve this goal. In other words, what do you need to be good at? Make sure not to confuse a process with an outcome. For example, if “getting good exam marks” is the outcome, then “being good at studying” and “being good in exams” are the processes.

Make sure to think about:

1. Mental health
2. Focus and concentration
3. Time management and procrastination
4. Studying skill and how efficiently you use your time

You can have great time management but if you study 12% slower than the top-level competition, you'll find it difficult to achieve a top-level goal.

Step 3: Evaluate your level

For each of the processes you've identified, ask yourself:

1. How good am I at this right now?
2. How do I know I am this good?
3. What condition must be true for my evaluation of my level to be accurate?
4. What is everything I do with regards to this process? (Think of this step like an instruction manual for someone else to do exactly what you do – be as specific as possible)
5. Is it possible that I am not as good as I think I am?
6. If yes, what do I need to learn more about to be certain of my level?



Take Notes

Step 4: Find the 1%

For each of the processes you've now critically dissected, identify just a single area you could be better in. It doesn't matter if it is technically "1%" or not. It could be only 0.01% but the idea is to look for these tiny improvements wherever possible.

Improvements could be about:

1. Being more consistent
2. Taking less time
3. Being more intentional
4. Reflecting more regularly or critically
5. Learning more about a skill or a technique
6. Experimenting with a new way of doing things in a small way

The final two points, learning and experimenting are typically the most powerful gains you can have because they compound the most easily.

You may not think that "learning more" is a gain, since there isn't always an instant outcome that tells you that you got better, but this is **often** what is needed when you are **unsure** about how to improve.

For example, if you are unsure **how to study more efficiently and spend 10 minutes less per day**, then the first step is to learn how to do this, followed by experimenting on it.

If you think about **progress**, someone who has tried and failed is one step closer to their goal than someone who has not tried. And someone who knows what to try is a step closer than someone who doesn't even know!

Step 5: Rinse and repeat

Repeat this process starting from step **three** once a week. Repeat the process every 3-6 months.



Take Notes

After doing this cycle for 4 or 5 times, you should start to tune in to marginal gains naturally, without needing to use this system every time. But always keep it in your toolkit for complicated, especially challenging goals that feel overwhelming.

This process is the habit that gives birth to habits. It's like wishing for more wishes!

Task

Download the worksheet and start tracking some marginal gains. If you have an academic marginal gain, you may want to check out the video on the next sub-lesson first. Feel free to mark this as complete to watch that, then come back to work on this.



Take Notes



Note

Take Notes

In later lessons, you will learn about Kolb's Experiential Learning Cycle, which is a framework that powers improvement. Using Kolb's cycle is the engine that kicks Marginal Gains up a level. We've broken this down into highly-specific and nuanced steps, which are rarely taught. When you learn about Kolb's, you will be able to combine it with this Marginal Gains Tracker, but before then, you need to develop some basic experience with using this without Kolb's, to make the integration smoother and more manageable.

How are you feeling?

1.2K responses



Join the discussion

B *I* U       

405 COMMENTS

 Most Voted ▼



Sukhman Phangura

🕒 1 year ago

Here are the marginal gain goals I have developed. I have also added parts of the 30 day plan (like barriers, limiting habits and scripted action) My Goals Fostering a growth mindset and being able to flourish in the face of adversity. Duration (within the first month of taking this course so by the New Year). Completing up to Pre-Calculus 12 before my February 28th, 2022 deadline for Health Information Science. Completing remaining courses and other learning interests (Physics, Chemistry, Biology, Calculus, English, French, Spanish, self teaching Punjabi to myself again,



Take Notes

coding and cooking/moving out plan for when I move out). Duration: Once finished up to Pre-calculus 12 for February first deadline finish the remaining courses/learning interests... [Read more »](#)

^ 97 → Reply



Aakanksha Desai

↻ Reply to [Sukhman Phangura](#) ⌚ 5 months ago

I think described processes are still very outcome oriented mostly to finish syllabus and not related to learning skills and how to improve on that.

Plus please stick to the worksheet as much as possible. Don't try to make it easier by changing the questions.

Omitting to answer a question because you think its not relevant is again dunning krugger effect. Hope this helps others.

^ 14 → Reply



Giovanni Joris

↻ Reply to [Sukhman Phangura](#) ⌚ 1 year ago

How is it going?

I find a lot of similarities here and this makes me feel not alone but also motivated to give and find mutual support in how we can move towards this.

Wishing you courage and growth.

^ 8 → Reply



Luis Rodriguez

↻ Reply to [Sukhman Phangura](#) ⌚ 1 year ago

Hey there, I just want to say thx to you. This comment is probably one of the best in the course, thx for taking the time to write. I hope you are helping other as this comment is helping me. 😊

^ 14 → Reply



Ike Maldonado

⌚ 1 year ago

I really like the idea that one small habit change can affect another, both positively and/or negatively.

^ 29 → Reply



Take Notes

**Luis Rivera Cabrera**Reply to [Ike Maldonado](#) 1 year ago

This is probably what my wrestling coach focused on the most. To be 1 percent better each day. I can't believe how right he was.

9

Reply

**Ashton Sheares** AdminReply to [Luis Rivera Cabrera](#) 1 year ago

Yes, a lot of methods taught in sports actually does help with studying too.

10

Reply

**Duong Nguyen**Reply to [Ashton Sheares](#) 3 months ago

how could i send my practices to recieve the feedback?

2

Reply

**Ashton Sheares** AdminReply to [Duong Nguyen](#) 3 months ago

Hope onto our Discord community: <https://discord.gg/icanstudy>

This will be locked, information on how to unlock it will be here:

<https://icanstudy.com/discordintro/>

Once unlocked, you can scroll through the channels to QUESTIONS in order to post your work for feedback.

2

Reply

**Lily TranCat**

1 year ago

I have a habit of setting large, complicated end goals and procrastinating on them because of it. The marginal gains framework seems like the exact opposite of what I've been doing, but I'm excited to use it!

24

Reply

**Kamna Singh**Reply to [Lily TranCat](#) 10 months ago

Take Notes

same!!!

^ 1

→ Reply



calvin tang

🕒 1 year ago

- i think this is a detailed version of Plan-do-check-act cycle.
- Step 2 , dissect a goal, stating clear and specific processes to achieve a goal (PLAN)
- step 3, evaluate, that is, identify check, a signal(s), that you are growing or declining objectively. (human is subject to self deception)
- step 4, find 1%, act , that is, improvement, micro habit, process improvement
- Very detailed and specific; but this PDCA cycle requires a mature mind or counsellor to support/supervise ...not easy to perform in young mind or mind with ADHD / learning difficulties

^ 12

→ Reply



Siani Senthil kumar

🗨️ Reply to [calvin tang](#) 🕒 1 year ago

So I have learning difficulties – specifically ADHD – and yeah, this seems really hard to implement because I've tried to do this before and haven't succeeded properly. However, I know some of my weaknesses which some of you MAY experience – never make the 1% goal something that will take too much executive function to do. Make sure that you re-energize your 'executive function pool' when you use a lot of it i.e. when you implement these techniques and force your brain to do things differently, it will literally hurt sometimes – whenever you find yourself needing to look away, you WILL need to take a break in order to come back; but obviously, your break needs to be... [Read more »](#)

^ 21

→ Reply



Mia Mcclary

🗨️ Reply to [Siani Senthil kumar](#) 🕒 1 year ago

I have ADHD as well and this was a great reminder for me, this is something i will also apply to my new regamine for success. Thank you!❤️

^ 2

→ Reply



Joseph Mandapat

🗨️ Reply to [Siani Senthil kumar](#) 🕒 1 year ago



Take Notes

Thank you for this advice. A lot of what you just said really resonated with me. I would always try to work against and fight against my ADHD mind and would constantly feel exhausted and mentally drained. It came to a point where I was completely burnt out and ended up not doing anything for an extended period of time. Now with what you said, I will be working WITH my ADHD, and applying what you said to my "Marginal Gains Goals". To add further to what you said about doing things that don't take up your executive function, I saw this video by the YouTuber (How to ADHD) is to list down activities you would like to do doing... [Read more »](#)

^ 3 ➔ Reply



Christopher Swacha

➔ Reply to [calvin tang](#) ⌚ 1 year ago

I would argue the intent between Marginal Gains and PDCA is similar – but the time horizon of the process differs. PDCA is usually done on an annual basis, while marginal gains closes the loop every time you decide to measure and update the experiment.

^ 0 ➔ Reply



Ashton Sheares Admin

➔ Reply to [Christopher Swacha](#) ⌚ 1 year ago

If you already have implemented a structured approach, you will find similarities and it's often much more superior than not having a system.

One thing that we heavily emphasise in marginal gains is finding that next achievable 1% step.

^ 4 ➔ Reply



Jayden Hooper

⌚ 1 year ago

I've spent a few days implementing this into my life. I have found massive achievements in motivation and have felt a huge kick start moving forward through using this. Highly recommend!

^ 11 ➔ Reply



Lamees Abu Mwise

⌚ 1 year ago

After doing this cycle for 4 or 5 times, you should start to tune in to marginal gains naturally, without needing to use this system every time.

what does this exactly mean?



Take Notes

 7  Reply**Christo Alex** Reply to [Lamees Abu Mwise](#) ⌚ 6 months ago

You tend to become more aware of these small gains that you are making and accumulating. Thus these steps tend to run in the back of your mind thereby reducing the need to actively tune in and see the marginal gains.

 1  Reply**Daisy Lord**

⌚ 1 year ago

Can anyone help me, I don't know what kind of thing to write for Step 3 Evaluation – 3 What condition must be true for my evaluation of my level to be accurate?

 4  Reply**Ashton Sheares** Admin Reply to [Daisy Lord](#) ⌚ 1 year ago

This is a finding a standard for you to measure your level accurately. For example if you want to improve your focus, you keep count of the number of times you get distracted. This “count” is something you can use to evaluate your level accurately.

So we usually want you to find something numeric to quantify your level in order to track your progress.

 21  Reply**Eleana Xu** Reply to [Ashton Sheares](#) ⌚ 1 year ago

I'm a bit unsure about how to interpret “What condition must be true for my evaluation of my level to be accurate”. For example, for the process “staying motivated and refreshed when I study”, my evaluation is “I usually have no problem being motivated to study because of deadlines, but I have trouble feeling refreshed to study”. I thought the conditions might be something like “I know what being motivated and refreshed means in relation to study” and “I know myself well enough to assess my behaviours”, like Justin's examples of “what conditions must be true for my belief to be true” in the previous lessons. This was my initial interpretation, but after reading the above comment I just wanted... [Read more »](#)

 1  Reply

Take Notes

**Ashton Sheares** AdminReply to [Eleana Xu](#) 1 year ago

Hi Eleana, you need to find something that can be used to measure what you want to achieve.

So for "staying motivated and refreshed when I study", you may want to count the number of times you get distracted in the study session.

Or you may want to set up your environment beforehand and remove possible distractions.

From what you have said, I think you are already aware of what needs to be done.

^ 5

→ Reply

**Eleana Xu**Reply to [Ashton Sheares](#) 1 year ago

Thanks for clarifying!

^ 0

→ Reply

**Mae Lucchino**

1 year ago

I'm now realizing that I've been practicing marginal gains for at least a year now, unknowingly! I used to want to work as a professional artist, and in my efforts to achieve the goal of "getting good at art" through self-studying, I divided up all the elements of art I'd need to master (anatomy, painting, composition, etc.) and then divided those categories even further. I would pursue one or two subjects for a long period, evaluating where I was, how I could get better, acquiring the resources I needed to improve, and then I evaluated my progress everyday. I would note what I'd improved at, where I failed, what I could try differently and how what I was attempting to... [Read more »](#)

^ 4

→ Reply

**Mia McClary**

1 year ago

Does ICanStudy also help with testing/exams? I get very serious mental blocks during tests, even if i dont really feel anxious. So i am unsure of the cause but it would be great to get some guidance with that as well.

^ 3

→ Reply



Take Notes

**Dominik Filliger**

🕒 1 year ago

How does one track 1% improvement in anything?

I have no problem in listing up things I would like to improve on, but I am not sure at what stage I would say "ah yes I improved by 1% on XY"

^ 2 ➔ Reply

**Ashton Sheares**

Admin

➔ Reply to [Dominik Filliger](#) 🕒 1 year ago

Improvements could be about:

1. Being more consistent
2. Taking less time
3. Being more intentional
4. Reflecting more regularly or critically
5. Learning more about a skill or a technique
6. Experimenting with a new way of doing things in a small way

^ 2 ➔ Reply

**Dominik Filliger**➔ Reply to [Ashton Sheares](#) 🕒 1 year ago

This is not really answering my question. I have the list, but I find it hard to judge if I improved by 1% or not. How does one measure improvement?

^ 2 ➔ Reply

**Ashton Sheares**

Admin

➔ Reply to [Dominik Filliger](#) 🕒 1 year ago

1. Measure your consistence (frequency/duration).
2. Measure your time.
3. Measure your intention (number of set tasks accomplished)



Take Notes

It's about making sure there is a measureable improvement so you can see the 1% difference.

^ 14 → Reply



roufail boughos

↻ Reply to [Ashton Sheares](#) ⌚ 7 months ago

hi Ashton, i have a problem with measuring the 1% lets says that my goal is to watch less YouTube videos during the day to track that i will get the history in YouTube setting so i can see how many videos i click on. lets say first day i watched 15videos (because of my procrastination) seconde day 10vides. we can see that there is 5 videos less so does that mean that i had a 1% gain or 5% gain do you see what i mean how can mesure that watching 5videos less = x%gain ?

✎ Last edited 7 months ago by roufail boughos

^ 0 → Reply



Ashton Sheares Admin

↻ Reply to [roufail boughos](#) ⌚ 7 months ago

Porbabaly track the total time duration instead of number of videos. As 15 videos could be 15mintues and 10 videos could be 10 hours.

^ 0 → Reply



roufail boughos

↻ Reply to [Ashton Sheares](#) ⌚ 7 months ago

ok, i get that point but i'm asking how i'm i suppose to calculate the 1% gain? is there a formula or a function that tell me that i gain x%.

example:

lets say the goal is that my time watch become less videos on youtube (maximum 45min/day)

before starting the journey i know that i watch 3h/day.

first day: I watch 2,5h how much gain did i make ?

Seconde day: i watch 45min only how much gain did i make?

third day : i watch 4h how much gain is that?

Forth day: i watch 15min only how much did i gain?

^ 0 → Reply



Take Notes

**Ashton Sheares** AdminReply to [roufail boughos](#) 7 months ago

There is no strict formula. You want to set a marginal gain that is a gain from your previous self.

0 Reply

**Maxime VAUDRAN**Reply to [Ashton Sheares](#) 8 months ago

And how can we measure our efficiency?

For example, how do we measure our skill in advancing the relationship between ideas? Prioritization?

0 Reply

**Ashton Sheares** AdminReply to [Maxime VAUDRAN](#) 8 months ago

Your question is too broad. Examples have been given in the text, however, you can think of the marginal gains when you think of the process in applying the technique. For example, if you have covered the traffic-light system, "advancing the relationship between ideas" would relate to inquiry-based learning, particularly through having more broad questions that lead to specific questions during the red-light step in the traffic light system.

2 Reply

**Tobi Bolaji-Joseph**

1 year ago

So the summary of this sub-section about marginal gains in one sentence is that small constant improvements over time lead to massive and drastic changes in a positive direction.

2 Reply

**Ashton Sheares** AdminReply to [Tobi Bolaji-Joseph](#) 1 year ago

Yes, but to add onto that, you have to make sure you are tracking those small improvements, ensuring you are improving towards your goals.



Take Notes

^ 4

→ Reply

**Alesja Mjalika**

🕒 1 year ago

Hi, I need help please. I can't figure out step 3 points 1 and 3. Seems like I'm struggling to find a measurement how to evaluate the process I choose. My goal is to successfully finish a certain project at work. For step 2 I wrote down over 25 processes and still could keep going. However I understood that at this stage, it's better to choose 1 most important one and do the rest of the steps on it. Then with time, as this gets easier add more processes from step 2. Please correct me if I'm wrong. I choose "being good at prioritisation". 1. How good am I at this right now? I'm struggling to properly answer this question.... [Read more »](#)

^ 2

→ Reply

**Afl Ols**

🕒 1 year ago

Can anybody give an example of the **processes** in Step 2? Say if I want to get a high score in math exams. Should I incorporate the 4 tips in Step 2 into one process or for each think of a process?

^ 1

→ Reply

**Ashton Sheares**

Admin

↻ Reply to [Afl Ols](#) 🕒 1 year ago

The 4 tips are just different aspects of your study-life that you can think about. For an example, one was given: if "getting good exam marks" is the outcome, then "being good at studying" and "being good in exams" are the processes.

^ 3

→ Reply

**Frane Ivasovic**↻ Reply to [Afl Ols](#) 🕒 1 year ago

I think the more detailed evaluation of the single processes is in step 3, while in step 2 you are dissecting the goal, and the points showed are something that you should always account for, in your goal dissection.

^ 2

→ Reply



Take Notes

**Matthias Emgenbroich**

🕒 1 year ago

To step 4 point 3: What is meant with “being more intentional”? Like knowing what I’m doing and why I’m doing it? Or something else?

^ 1 ➔ Reply

**Ashton Sheares** Admin🗨 Reply to [Matthias Emgenbroich](#) 🕒 1 year ago

It could be tracking your focus, eg: the number of times you get distracted.

^ 1 ➔ Reply

**Hasnaien Ahmed**

🕒 1 year ago

Honestly, I don’t think I have had to sit down and dissect the problems/bad habits/challenges of my life the way that I have in this step + in filling out the 30-day plan for the catalyst session. It feels good to finally know what to do and what not to do, but I am truly feeling concerned about my ability to stick to all of these different kinds of marginal gains and I am also worried that when my life becomes a trainwreck during the mess of the coming clinical rotations (3rd year MD student doing into pediatrics, surgery, psychiatry, and obs/gyn starting a week from today), I will stop doing all of this stuff, then pick it up again... [Read more »](#)

^ 1 ➔ Reply

**Ashton Sheares** Admin🗨 Reply to [Hasnaien Ahmed](#) 🕒 1 year ago

You will find as you get into later years and your professional life, there is a greater need to organise your life.

This comes in the form of greater stress as you take on larger roles and people either learn to problem solve under this pressure or just quit.

We’re trying to equip you with all the tools before it reachest this stage, and for some people, they would have already reached their limit before 3rd year university. It’s a valid worry you have, but if you don’t take control of your life, your life will take control of you in a much more unpleasant way.

^ 3 ➔ Reply

**Sonique Steenberg**

🕒 1 year ago



Take Notes

To what level of detail do the identified processes need to be in Step 2? Should it be broad such as 'Exam Technique'? I am a bit confused when I get to Step 3 question 4. In this case, do I literally explain how I navigate exams e.g. in reading time looking for the difficult and heavily weighted questions and planning which questions I do when writing time starts? Also, the '1%'s in Step 4, do I find a small improvement, implement it for the first week, reflect, make improvements on those improvements while thinking of a different 'new' improvement to implement the next week? Is that what is meant by compounding marginal gains? Thanks

^ 1 ➔ Reply



Ashton Sheares Admin

🗨 Reply to [Sonique Steenberg](#) ⌚ 1 year ago

Mostly yes to everything you said, the more specific the better. We are really looking for things that you are not currently doing in order to find that improvement.

The only thing to look out for is that you may not need to think of different "new" improvements each week. Sometimes it's good enough to stick to current marginal gains if they are still giving you the 1% benefit.

^ 0 ➔ Reply



Nick Johnson

⌚ 1 year ago

I'm curious what the mental health processes could look like that others have? My specific goal is to build the skills to become a front-end engineer through coding an average of two well-spent hours a day, with a 70% hit rate of actually doing this. Here are my 'mental health processes' and some of the reasoning behind them: The 70% hit rate gives me the flexibility if I really can't code that day, I have margin for error and won't beat myself up. If I am feeling very unmotivated or stressed after work, I will let myself do a less demanding session where I don't learn new material but will practice writing code that mixes together concepts I am already... [Read more »](#)

📝 Last edited 1 year ago by Nick Johnson

^ 1 ➔ Reply



Jan de Klerk

🗨 Reply to [Nick Johnson](#) ⌚ 1 year ago

Hi Nick, I agree with your mental health view. Could be such a broad discussion and everyone views it differently. But I think the fact that you are creating that space for "life to happen" with a 70% hit rate is well measurable and also does not discourage you if you feel like you 100% hit rate. Sometimes those less demanding sessions ends up bei



Take Notes

efficient sessions. I have done a similar thing with trying to do 85% of my daily tasks that I put onto my calendar. This has made me so much more aware of what I am putting into my calendar and being more realistic of what can... [Read more »](#)

^ 0

→ Reply

**Zac Seth**→ Reply to [Nick Johnson](#) ⌚ 1 year ago

A different approach that James Clear talks about in Atomic Habits (great book for this stuff, by the way – I've seen it in the background, on Justin's bookshelf in some of his videos) is that of the "2 minute habit". The idea is that you set a goal that's really, really, really easy to achieve so you can easily do it 100% of the time (so, aim to spend 2 minutes every day programming – or 5, whatever works for you). If it turns out that you end up doing 2 hours instead of 2 minutes? Bonus. But, even if you didn't, you've achieved your goal and you get the mental boost from achieving that. I think the risk... [Read more »](#)

^ 3

→ Reply

**Nick Johnson**→ Reply to [Zac Seth](#) ⌚ 1 year ago

This is a good point. I will keep this in mind. Thanks.

^ 1

→ Reply

**Natali Obayuwana**

⌚ 10 months ago

My main problem is to encode detailed information. Most of the time I try to read everything that I want to learn of this topic and try to figure out the general idea. Then I write it down and looking for the relationship between them and try to prioritize them. But when it comes to processing detailed information, my main problem is that I can't keep up with the amount of it and it feels like too much cognitive load at this specific moment. Not slightly uncomfortable but I feel so much discomfort that I sometimes start to believe I am fundamentally stupid. And I re read these specific terms that I need to comprehend a couple times. It honestly... [Read more »](#)

^ 1

→ Reply

**Ashton Sheares** Admin→ Reply to [Natali Obayuwana](#) ⌚ 10 months ago

You're not quite in the correct place to ask this question. I recommend that you submit your work for feedback on discord or using the expert feedback function.



Take Notes

^ 0

→ Reply

**Nurdin Hassan**

🕒 6 months ago

-> Step 1: My goal is to achieve a 99+ atar for vce to maximize my chances of making it into medicine. -> Step 2 and Step 3: Got to improve on fixing my weak studying techniques, and need to change my whole studying system altogether to attain a deeper level of understanding for my subjects, especially through optimizing my encoding and retrievals. Evaluation: Right now I am horrible at encoding, but fairly improving on my retrievals. My encoding is horrible because I can never understand a topic to its full extent quickly, and my retrieving is improving as I am able to retain more of what I learn longer, so I don't need to retrieve as much. To measure... [Read more »](#)

^ 1

→ Reply

**Maximilian Jopp**

🕒 4 months ago

Hi Ashton, I just watched the Kolb's lecture and during watching, the marginal gain lecture made a lot more sense to me. Am I roughly understanding the concept correctly? Step 1: Anchor the goal: covers the big main goal Step 2: Dissect the goal: covers the (mainly processed orientated) sub-goals to achieve the main goal (Step 1) Step 4: Find the 1%: covers the sub-sub-goals (which are here called marginal gains), to reach the sub-goal (Step 2) With Step 3 I reflect, if it is necessary to improve the sub-goals further and if it is necessary to create other marginal gains. With the Kolb's I reflect my daily work, which I do to reach my marginal gains. Thanks a lot,... [Read more »](#)

📝 Last edited 4 months ago by Maximilian Jopp

^ 1

→ Reply

**Ashton Sheares**

Admin

🗨 Reply to [Maximilian Jopp](#) 🕒 4 months ago

Yes, that's right 😊

^ 0

→ Reply

**Maximilian Jopp**🗨 Reply to [Ashton Sheares](#) 🕒 4 months ago

Great, then I'm glad 😊

One question about *Step 5* from Marginal gains:



Take Notes

- *Step 5: Rinse and repeat* directly on the website says, how often we should repeat which steps.
- *Step 5: Reflection* on the worksheet gives some questions to reflect on the daily progress of the marginal gains.

So in my eyes they say something different.

Do I understand it correct, that I should repeat the marginal gains in the recommended order (step three once a week; step two once every 3 months.) but instead of the questions from *Step 5: Reflection*, I do the Kolb's every day, since I dive even deeper in reflection with the Kolb's?

Thanks a lot again.

Maximilian

 Last edited 4 months ago by Maximilian Jopp

^ 0

→ Reply



Ashton Sheares Admin

 Reply to [Maximilian Jopp](#)  4 months ago

Step 5: Rinse and repeat

Repeat this process starting from step three once a week. Repeat the process from step two once every 3 months.

The everyday part is just a quick reflection of how your step 4 is going.

^ 0

→ Reply



Andy Arribasplata Muñoz

 4 months ago

Paso1: metas: 1.Obtener la tesis de gc 2.Practica matematicas autodidactamente leyendo libros Paso2: Procesos: para m1 y m2: Ser bueno leyendo(p1), organizando informacion y ser mas eficiente(p2) Paso3: 1.No soy nada bueno 2.no entender lo que leo,ser lento, y obtener malas calificaciones o bajas 3.obtener buenas calificaciones 4.Intentó usar la forma supongo mas facil de chunkmap, no he realizado 1 hora de pre-estudio por realizar otra cosa que me emocionaba y por sentimiento me consumo tiempo, pero cuando ya se habia avanzado material icanstudy todavia enseñaba cosas muy generales y no tan practicas 5.Muy posible 6. Aprender a leer mejor Entender lo que se dice en clase A ser mas consistente en mi horario Paso4: para p1: Aprender mas a... [Read more »](#)

^ 1

→ Reply



Take Notes

**Ariya Wijaya**

🕒 1 year ago

how long do you normally reflect on this one and does it take longer on the first cycle because you need to individually visualize the process that is needed and the goals that you want to achieve?

^ 0 ➔ Reply

**Ashton Sheares**

Admin

🔁 Reply to [Ariya Wijaya](#) 🕒 1 year ago

The beginning is always hard and more time-consuming for any skill. After awhile, reflecting properly is done really quick and can be finished within a few minutes.

^ 5 ➔ Reply

**Catherine Gervais**

🕒 1 year ago

I'm reviewing my due dates for the next six weeks every morning and deciding on the next action for the next two assignments due that I'm capable of completely finishing that day. I have realized I need to be working on both classes every day, not planning to binge a week before assignments are due.

^ 0 ➔ Reply

**Aldo Bakijasi**

🕒 1 year ago

Hello, i've got a question with regard to the marginal gains applied to the processes of learning. what could be an optimum number of processes to focus on when working with the marginal gains(in a certain period of time)? Personally i've come up with more than 10 processes and if i keep going it might become like 20. Is it better to focus on a lot of processes at a time or just select the most important few to start with?

📝 Last edited 1 year ago by Aldo Bakijasi

^ 0 ➔ Reply

**Ashton Sheares**

Admin

🔁 Reply to [Aldo Bakijasi](#) 🕒 1 year ago

The optimal number differs depending on how well you are able to keep track of them. You can begin with something low, like 1 or 2 and work your way up.



Take Notes

If you are tracking 10, you should make sure that you are actually gaining those 1% in all 10 goals. If not, you should cut back.

^ 3 ➔ Reply



Bezal Stephen

➔ Reply to [Ashton Sheares](#) 1 year ago

All 10 goals at the same time? or more like work on 1 one day, 3 the next, and so on ?

^ 0 ➔ Reply



Ashton Sheares Admin

➔ Reply to [Bezal Stephen](#) 1 year ago

If you are tracking 10 goals, then you need to be able to do this concurrently.

^ 2 ➔ Reply



Bezal Stephen

➔ Reply to [Ashton Sheares](#) 1 year ago

oh, alright thank you :). I'd start off with 1 or 2 then ... also one of my processes is "better mental health" how do I prepare an "instruction manual" for that. I did something like, "Start finding things that can help me – meditating, etc., try taking break walks, cycling and find a support system to lean on". I find it hard to be more specific than this. So is this fine and working 1% gains on this should be okay?

^ 0 ➔ Reply



Ashton Sheares Admin

➔ Reply to [Bezal Stephen](#) 1 year ago

"better mental health" is an overall goal. The process would be more like working on your 'meditation/focus training'.
Then you break it down into 1% goals for specific things about meditation – like making sure you are doing 10minutes each day.
You need to be very specific with your 1% so that it's achievable and measurable.

^ 3 ➔ Reply



Bezal Stephen

➔ Reply to [Ashton Sheares](#) 1 year ago



Take Notes

Got it, thanks 😊

^ 0

➡ Reply



Krista Velkova

🕒 1 year ago

Why is it essential to set the goal for no less than 9 months? Would it be bad if you have less time to achieve the goal?

📝 Last edited 1 year ago by Krista Velkova

^ 0

➡ Reply



Ashton Sheares

Admin

🗨 Reply to [Krista Velkova](#) 🕒 1 year ago

because things often change beyond those 9 months and it's not useful to plan something that will be changed later.

Remember, these are more your marginal goals that is required to hit your long-term goals.

^ 2

➡ Reply



Rachana Hourt

🕒 1 year ago

I'm currently struggling to fill out Step 3. Could someone please give me an example or some sort of explanation, please?

I can't seem to answer any of these questions.

Thanks!

^ 0

➡ Reply



Ashton Sheares

Admin

🗨 Reply to [Rachana Hourt](#) 🕒 1 year ago

Please give your step 1 and step 2. Then people might be able to give suggestions.

^ 0

➡ Reply



Rachana Hourt

🗨 Reply to [Ashton Sheares](#) 🕒 1 year ago



Take Notes

My goal is to get an "A" (which I personally think will be hard to get) on the exam that will take place at the end of my academic year.

Step 2: good exam techniques, higher ability to recall details, don't procrastinate, Use knowledge to solve problems more efficiently and faster, Ability to learn concepts efficiently and faster, good stress management...

Currently, I'm not that good with these techniques and I don't do quite well on curveball questions. My ability to understand, remember and recall info isn't so good.

^ 0 ➔ Reply



Ashton Sheares

Admin

➔ Reply to [Rachana Hourt](#) ⌚ 1 year ago

An easy example to take out would be "don't procrastinate".

You can count the number of times you get distracted during a study session in order to assess yourself, which is normally the easiest way.

But take note that your marginal gains can be broken down even further. Like taking out the textbook, putting away your phone, not using youtube/social media.

^ 1 ➔ Reply



Fabio Nascimento Vidigal

⌚ 1 year ago

I work with something very incipient and specific in a winner-takes-all market. How good is a goal such as "be one of the top-level references in my profession in my office?" or "be one of the top-level references in my profession in my city?"

^ 0 ➔ Reply



Ashton Sheares

Admin

➔ Reply to [Fabio Nascimento Vidigal](#) ⌚ 1 year ago

If that's your goal, then go for it. Then work backwards to see what marginal gains you can track and progress through in order to achieve those goals.

^ 1 ➔ Reply



Ryan Neagle

⌚ 1 year ago

Should we make a goal to get good exam results in general or should we make a goal for each subject?



Take Notes

 0  Reply**Ariya Wijaya** 1 year ago

for step 3 and 4 it is stated that we must evaluate every processes that we've identified in step 2, so for example if there is 11 processes in order for me to reach the goals that I have, I need to evaluate all 11 of them then for step 4 I need to search the 1% improvement in all 11 processes? because the first time I do the marginal gains worksheet, I wasn't really paying attention to the step by step of how to do the marginal gains worksheet and I thought that I just need to do the evaluation in step 3 for the goals that I have in step 1 and it's the same case for the... [Read more »](#)

 0  Reply**Ashton Sheares**

Admin

 Reply to [Ariya Wijaya](#)  1 year ago

Hi Ariya, you do indeed need to track your marginal gains so when first doing marginal gains and tracking, just start with 1 or 2.

Going straight to 11 from 0 will be overwhelming in the beginning and much too difficult.

 0  Reply**Ariya Wijaya** Reply to [Ashton Sheares](#)  1 year ago

Ok and the evaluation of my current level is intended for the processes not the goals itself right?

 0  Reply**Ashton Sheares**

Admin

 Reply to [Ariya Wijaya](#)  1 year ago

Well.. the process is to reach the goals.

 0  Reply**Ariya Wijaya** Reply to [Ashton Sheares](#)  1 year ago

Yeah, what I mean is that if the goals are for example getting good exams mark, and the processes are getting good at studying. Should I be good at getting good grades or should the evaluation be on the processes?



Take Notes

studying. I just wanted to clarify to make sure I don't get it wrong but I assume if you already evaluate the processes then it's the same as evaluating the goals.

^ 0 ➔ Reply



Ashton Sheares Admin

➔ Reply to [Ariya Wijaya](#) ⌚ 1 year ago

You need to keep doing Step 2. "getting good grades" or "getting good at studying" is still too broad.

You want to break it down even more by focusing on a specific studying skill. For example: spacing, interleaving and retrieval. And making sure you using those skills properly.

^ 0 ➔ Reply



Aakanksha Desai

⌚ 1 year ago

If processes are going correct means outcome will surely be seen. So can outcome centric goals be taken as a valid indicator for evaluating the processes?

Like if process of consistent revision with proper retrieval by making connections is taking place. Then can I evaluate it as- I must be able to score well in exam.

^ 0 ➔ Reply



Ashton Sheares Admin

➔ Reply to [Aakanksha Desai](#) ⌚ 1 year ago

Of course it can be used as an indicator since the processes is related to your goals. However there will often be better measure you can make that are more specific to tracking your marginal goals.

Eg: getting 100% doesn't mean you don't procrastinate or get distracted. It's a good indicator you're doing well, but there are better things you can track to examine your focus.

^ 0 ➔ Reply



Aakanksha Desai

⌚ 1 year ago

While journaling daily-

Do we have to decide 1% improvement target for next day and track next day?

or

Just look out for 1 % improvement throughout the same day?



Take Notes

 Last edited 1 year ago by Aakanksha Desai

^ 0 ➔ Reply



Ashton Sheares Admin

↻ Reply to [Aakanksha Desai](#) ⌚ 1 year ago

You want to be setting and tracking marginal gains.

^ 0 ➔ Reply



Dhanik Samarakoon

⌚ 1 year ago

I'm not sure about point 4 on 'Evaluate your level', what does it mean by instruction manual? Is it about i will study in a session using the marginal gains or something else?

^ 0 ➔ Reply



Ashton Sheares Admin

↻ Reply to [Dhanik Samarakoon](#) ⌚ 1 year ago

Break down what you exactly due with regards to this process when you are evaluating it.
So this is liken to creating an "instruction manual" for this process.

^ 0 ➔ Reply



Dhanik Samarakoon

↻ Reply to [Ashton Sheares](#) ⌚ 1 year ago

So would it look something like this?

- 1) Before starting check schedule on google calendar
 - 2) Remove phone and laptop from reach
- and etc?

^ 0 ➔ Reply



Jordan Louis

⌚ 1 year ago

Hello, I am a little bit confused about the tracking of marginal gains and have a few questions. Are we supposed to fill this worksheet for each of our goals? For example I have goals regarding my musical instrument, drawing, school as well as courses I am following on my own specific with some goals, for example with my musical instrument which



Take Notes

better at playing jazz and the goal I am setting myself to at the moment is to just be consistent and play at least once a week making sure to do the exercises I'm given by my teacher. I don't know if it is specific... [Read more »](#)

0 [Reply](#)



Ashton Sheares Admin

[Reply to Jordan Louis](#) 1 year ago

Hi Jordan, to answer your questions:

1. Yes, it is for each of your goals.
2. Try to follow the steps to break down your goals. If you feel it is not enough, try to think what else you can do or ask people on discord for suggestions. Indeed, it is better to say **"I'm going to work at least 30min everyday on that course"** as your marginal gain when your goal is "finish the course".
3. Try not to get overwhelmed by changing too many things at once. You definitely want to only keep track of 2 or even just 1 goal at the beginning until you form a better habit.

1 [Reply](#)



Mahra Aljneibi

1 year ago

I just want to be sure that I am doing this correctly. Currently, I am in my junior year of high school. My main goal is to be on the honors list when graduating next year. The two processes that I need to achieve are:

- 1- To build up the skills in studying efficiently by using the skill taught in ICS to be able to get great marks in all of my subjects.
- 2- To balance work and fun time. Since I tend to lose most of my time either studying for a long time or having too much fun (by binge-watching dramas on Netflix.

0 [Reply](#)



Dominik Nagy

1 year ago

What about performing under high levels of stress during an exam? I can write it anywhere apart from time management and procrastination. Or should I make a 5th point?



Take Notes

0 [Reply](#)



Ashton Sheares Admin

[Reply to Dominik Nagy](#) 1 year ago

Not quite sure what you're trying to ask here. You can indeed set this as a goal if you wish.

0 [Reply](#)



Bam Huynh

1 year ago

I am finding this emotionally challenging as I have a fixed mindset and I am aware of my tendencies to be perfectionistic and give up too soon. Is it normal to be emotionally distressed during this process?

0 [Reply](#)



Ashton Sheares Admin

[Reply to Bam Huynh](#) 1 year ago

It depends which part specifically you are having trouble with. It's definitely one of the harder things to do for certain people and we try to walk you through it in the catalyst session in planning out your next 30 days.

0 [Reply](#)



Melina De Four

1 year ago

I'm still confused about what to put for the question "What condition must be true for my evaluation of my level to be accurate?". I've read through some of the similar comments and what I've been seeing is that I have to find a way to measure my level. But exactly is the "condition" that I am putting? For example if my goal is "Spend less time on social media." Should the condition be "checking my Instagram feed 10 times during a 1 hour study session" and in that case when that condition is true then I have evaluated that my level is poor?

0 [Reply](#)



Ashton Sheares Admin

[Reply to Melina De Four](#) 1 year ago

So conditions that must be true in your example is that those are the and that you are not filling social media with another procrastination.



Take Notes

using the checks to instagram is an accurate evaluation of your level.

^ 0

→ Reply



Melina De Four

🗨 Reply to [Ashton Sheares](#) ⌚ 1 year ago

Ohhh okay I see thanks.

^ 0

→ Reply



Hamna Sajid

⌚ 1 year ago

I'm not sure if I've planned my gains correctly and would love some feedback. Step 1: My goal is to get A+/A in all my year end VCE exams and SACs. Step 2: I am a bit unsure regarding the processes as there are alot of things that I need to do better and focus on but the biggest areas that I need to improve are Procrastinate less and therefore have more time to study and work on different subjects efficiently. Scheduling my time effectively and folowng through on it + specifically detailing out everything that I need to do in a task so that I don't start tasks with half hearted attempts and have a clear plan of action... [Read more »](#)

📝 Last edited 1 year ago by Hamna Sajid

^ 0

→ Reply



Ashton Sheares Admin

🗨 Reply to [Hamna Sajid](#) ⌚ 1 year ago

We do deal with procrastination and scheduling later on in the course. Keep an eye out for them in technique training stage, those systems would defintely help with these goals that you have.

^ 0

→ Reply



Nicola Lienhardt

⌚ 1 year ago

What ist meant with "Make sure to think about: 1. Mental health etc."?
How am i supposed to incorporate those points? 😊

^ 0

→ Reply



Take Notes

**Lauro Borges**

🕒 1 year ago

I don't understand the reflection part of the worksheet, isn't that what's done in Kolb's?

^ 0

➡ Reply

**Ashton Sheares**

Admin

🗨 Reply to [Lauro Borges](#) 🕒 1 year ago

Yes it is. The worksheet is specially tailored for you to reflect and improve on your marginal gains.

^ 0

➡ Reply

**A Own**

🕒 1 year ago

Having a **weekly review** is very important in general just to have a clear perspective of where your life is headed and what can be changed

I set mine usually at **Friday morning** each week to review my week and schedule the next week

^ 0

➡ Reply

**Fabian Duran**

🕒 1 year ago

What's the minimum and maximum amount of processes you would recommend someone track at any given time?

^ 0

➡ Reply

**Ashton Sheares**

Admin

🗨 Reply to [Fabian Duran](#) 🕒 1 year ago

At the beginning, you can just begin with 1.

Then once you're comfortable, you can increase that to 2 or 3.

You don't really want to track too many things in the beginning, otherwise you run the risk of failing everything.

^ 0

➡ Reply



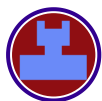
Take Notes

**Drew Rogers**

🕒 1 year ago

I think Goodhart's Law fits in well with this idea it is expressed simply as: "When a measure becomes a target, it ceases to be a good measure." in step two that is why we must identify the process

^ 0 ➡ Reply

**Surya Pali**

🕒 1 year ago

I just seek for a small clarification:

The question '**Is it possible that I am not as good as I think I am?**' in the Evaluation section – it would not be applicable if I have already evaluated myself of being very bad at the particular process, right? For example: My Goal requires me to be very very good at Time Management. So I have evaluated myself as being VERY BAD at it in the Evaluation section, the question '**Is it possible that I am not as good as I think I am?**' would have no utility or even be possible to apply here, right?

^ 0 ➡ Reply

**Ashton Sheares**

Admin

🗨 Reply to [Surya Pali](#) 🕒 1 year ago

Hi Surya,

This check is there mainly to let you reassess your evaluation. Usually people overestimate their ability, which is more concerning than people underestimating (which is much easier to fix). So don't worry about it too much if that's the case.

^ 1 ➡ Reply

**Jorge Espino**

🕒 1 year ago

Is it okay if I generalize a process or do I have to split that process up into multiple different processes and keep track of that?

^ 0 ➡ Reply

**Ashton Sheares**

Admin

🗨 Reply to [Jorge Espino](#) 🕒 1 year ago

It's better to be specific and measurable than to be too generalised.



Take Notes

^ 0

→ Reply

**Thuan Le**

🕒 1 year ago

I have known the story of marginal gain before. However I have a fear about 1% improvement everyday proportional to 1% more weight everyday. Example, if you add 1 push up everyday, then you will be able to have 365 push ups after 1 year, and more than 1000 push ups after 3 years, which seems impossible and unrealistic when you look at it. What I mean is that the further we go, the smaller % we can increase every time. Though I do not deny the HUGE benefit of marginal gains at all. It is a very powerful tool if we know how to utilize it. Maybe after we reach a high level enough, then 1% a week?

^ 0

→ Reply

**stefano ruello**↩ Reply to [Thuan Le](#) 🕒 11 months ago

You can "interleaving" your gains for example.
after you reach a good limit of 100 push-up in a day
you can start to add 1kg on your pushup. maybe doing at first less push-up. you reach again 100 and you add another KG
Or you can do a version more advanced, so pushup elevated... than push up with one hand etc etc
1% on focusing more on the quality of movement. 1% more focus for example contracting the muscle with more intention/effort etc etc
1% slower movement
There are a lot of variables that we can control.
At one point it is ok to reach a limit, but the limit is more far than you think

^ 0

→ Reply

**Ashton Sheares** Admin↩ Reply to [Thuan Le](#) 🕒 1 year ago

adding one pushup would be an additive gain, also physically there are more obvious limits. For learning, there are 1% gains that you can find and improve when after you accomplish other goals.

^ 0

→ Reply

**Stacy Cunningham**

🕒 1 year ago

Hi! So I've picked the goal, broke that down into processes, and then discussed marginal gain options (more generalized skills, like being better at scheduling)



Take Notes

etc.)

If I understand right, I just work on improving those marginal gain options with my best guess? Like setting goals for doing X-number of days studying a week and working to hit that would be towards marginal gains in being more consistent in general?

I guess it's the part about getting better at skills that apply more universally (as covered in the video in 3.2) that has me wondering if I should be looking at marginal gains a different way.

^ 0 ➔ Reply



Ashton Sheares Admin

➔ Reply to [Stacy Cunningham](#) 1 year ago

You don't need to 'guess' your marginal gains. TYou take a look at your current level and aim to improve it marginally – creating your marginal gain.

^ 0 ➔ Reply



Stacy Cunningham

➔ Reply to [Ashton Sheares](#) 1 year ago

Hey, Ashton! Thank you for your answer. Let me reword that, because I think I didn't explain it clearly given how you interpreted it. So let's say, my goal's marginal gain area/type/option/thing is to "be more consistent". Am I just paying attention to how my consistency improves just in the goal? And working on it in terms of just that goal? Or should I be looking at it on a universal level and trying to improve it there? Or both? The video in 3.2 focused on abstracting your marginal gain area/type/option/thing and improving it to positively impact areas universally....and I think that made the idea more formless and difficult to wrap my head around. Until told different, I'm just going... [Read more »](#)

✎ Last edited 1 year ago by Stacy Cunningham

^ 0 ➔ Reply



Ashton Sheares Admin

➔ Reply to [Stacy Cunningham](#) 1 year ago

For you question about "consistency" it is indeed in the context of a marginal gain improving just one goal. You don't want to complicate things by having one marginal gain improve multiple things for now.

Yes, it may be the case that it will have a universal effect, however just focus on one goal and improving that first to keep things simple as you will be improving either way.

^ 0 ➔ Reply



Take Notes

**Stacy Cunningham**Reply to [Ashton Sheares](#) 1 year ago

OK, cool, thank you!

^ 0

→ Reply

**Janine Hesse**

1 year ago

Hey,

for step one, would it be a valid goal to say "finish this course and improve my study techniques" instead of "finishing uni with this and that degree"? Because, I am intrinsically motivated to learn, whereas finishing my degree/career is just a necessity (one that I love, but a necessity nevertheless).

^ 0

→ Reply

**Ashton Sheares**

Admin

Reply to [Janine Hesse](#) 1 year ago

Yes, that'll be great!

^ 0

→ Reply

**Damian**

1 year ago

Hey guys, are you recommending using audio flashcard? I think it's gonna be great for microlearning as i can listen to them when on the walk, quizlet has that feature, unfortunately they restrict to 30 sec per flashcard but seems great

^ 0

→ Reply

**Ashton Sheares**

Admin

Reply to [Damian](#) 1 year ago

You can use audio flashcards particularly if you are driving or cycling in your commute.

^ 0

→ Reply

**Damian**Reply to [Ashton Sheares](#) 1 year ago

Take Notes

Can recommend some good software for that? I'm using quizlet but they limiting audio to 30 seconds, also tried brainscapes but they dont have that nice functionality like quizlet where program switches to next flashcard, any recommendations?

^ 0 ➔ Reply



Ashton Sheares Admin

➔ Reply to [Damian](#) ⌚ 1 year ago

30 seconds should be more than enough. If it requires more than 30seconds then the flashcard is most likely a concept which shouldn't be in your flashcard in the first place. If that's the case, I would highly recommend that you not touch flashcards until we cover it on the course.

^ 1 ➔ Reply



Aakanksha Desai

⌚ 1 year ago

Hi Ashton, I have identified that my goal needs improvements in many processes. I can work with only a few of them at a time. However I find it difficult to identify which among them is more significant to work on now. Like I have to nurture growth mindset, be good at time management, good at studying, good at retention, good at focus to name a few. Each of the processes have a number of sub processes also like those which are taught at various stages of the course. And one process cannot be mastered all at once. Maximum how many of them should I focus on each week? Is it that on weekly basis I can change the processes... [Read more »](#)

✎ Last edited 1 year ago by Aakanksha Desai

^ 0 ➔ Reply



Ashton Sheares Admin

➔ Reply to [Aakanksha Desai](#) ⌚ 1 year ago

A suggestion for priority is to have marginal gains for the lesson that you are up to on the course.

1. Everyone has a different cap on how many they can work on, please begin with 1 or 2 then work your way up if you feel comfortable with the number.

2. Repeat from step 3 once a week. However if there is something obviously wrong before then, you can change it before the weekly review.

3. Just follow the steps in the text. Work on 1 marginal gain at a time if you are unsure about juggling multiple.

^ 0 ➔ Reply



Take Notes



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Take Notes